

Taming Performance Anxiety

Giving your best, without fear paralyzing you

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Giving your best, without fear paralyzing you

Before a presentation, an exam, an interview, a deadline: your heart races, your mind blurs, the fear of not measuring up takes over. A little stress helps you perform — too much sabotages it.

This guide helps you understand where the fear comes from, detach your worth from the outcome, and tame your anxiety concretely.

Your intention

A situation where the fear of not measuring up blocks you: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

Where the fear of failing comes from

Performance anxiety often roots in self-esteem conditioned on success ('I'm worth it if I succeed'), fear of judgment, or demands learned early.

Understanding it loosens the stakes: it's not your life on the line at every test.

Example

Terrified at every presentation, Sami linked the fear to a childhood where only results were valued. It all became clear.

What the fear hides

What do you really fear behind failure (judgment, loss of worth, rejection)?

My conditioned esteem

Write: 'I'm worth it even if...' (complete with a possible failure).

→ *My worth isn't on the line at every test.*

The thoughts that paralyze

'I'll fail', 'everyone will see', 'if I fail, it's a catastrophe': catastrophizing raises stress and cuts off your means.

Reframing them restores your clarity at the key moment.

Example

Sure she'd 'mess it all up', Nia reframed to 'I'll do my best'. The pressure dropped.

Anxiety journal

Note: the catastrophe thought · a fairer version · the realistic worst (often manageable).

Reframe

Turn 'if I fail it's a catastrophe' into 'a test is an experience, not a verdict'.

→ *A test is an experience — not a verdict on me.*

Detaching your worth from your performance

You're worth it regardless of the outcome. Aiming for your best without judging yourself on the worst frees you from a pressure that, precisely, harms your performance.

You're far more than your results.

Example

By no longer making her worth depend on each result, Léa paradoxically performed better — freer.

My worth, beyond results

Write 5 reasons you have worth that have nothing to do with a performance.

Aim for best, not perfect

Reframe your goal as 'doing my best' rather than 'being perfect'.

→ *I aim for my best — without making my worth depend on the outcome.*

Taming it concretely

Concretely: prepare (uncertainty feeds anxiety), breathe and ground yourself before, turn stress into useful energy, and build reassuring rituals.

Well-channeled stress becomes an ally.

Example

With a breathing ritual and good preparation, Sofia turned her nerves into focus on the day.

My preparation

For your next test: what would preparing reduce in uncertainty (and so anxiety)?

My calming ritual

Note what calms you before (slow breathing, grounding, positive visualization).

→ *Prepared and grounded, I turn stress into energy.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- A little stress is normal and useful: it makes you alert.
- Prepare: it reduces uncertainty, and so anxiety.
- Breathe before (slow cycle) and ground yourself.
- Reframe 'I'll fail' into 'I'll do my best'.
- Aim for progress, not perfection; detach your worth from the outcome.
- If anxiety is overwhelming or chronic, support truly helps.

To fill in

Anxiety journal

The catastrophe thought	A fairer version	The realistic worst

My ritual

Before the test	During

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand where my fear of failing comes from.

Week 2 — Reframe the thoughts that paralyze.

Week 3 — Detach my worth from the outcome.

Week 4 — Tame it (preparation, breathing, ritual).

Your plan in 3 lines

- My worth, beyond results:
- My key reframe:
- My calming ritual:

TO CLOSE

Your worth doesn't depend on the outcome — give your best, at ease.

Your worth doesn't depend on the outcome.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.